

Inflation takes a toll on holiday cookout costs, survey finds

The price of an average Fourth of July cookout increased 4.1% from 2025 to 2026.

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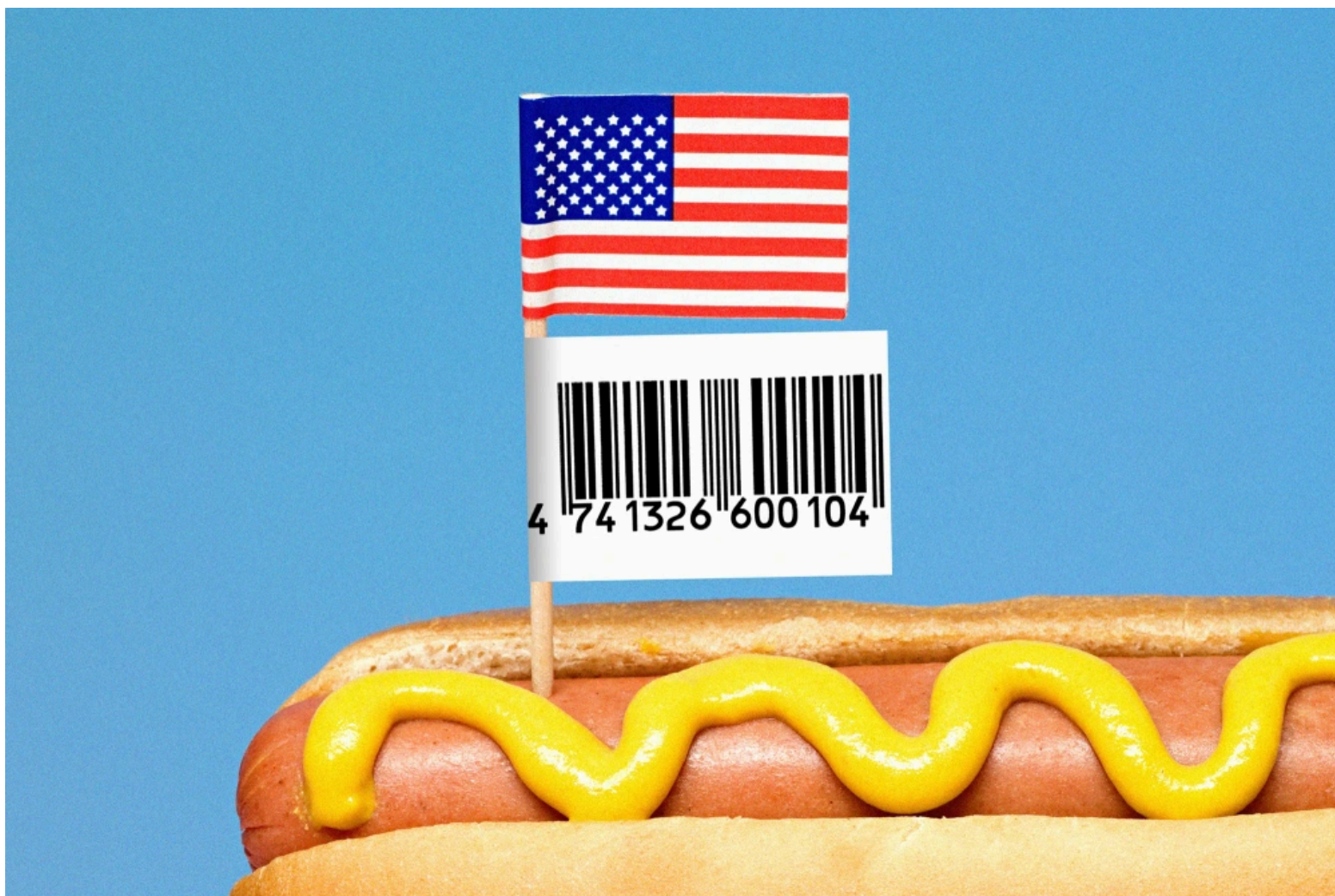


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By Ashley Mowreader

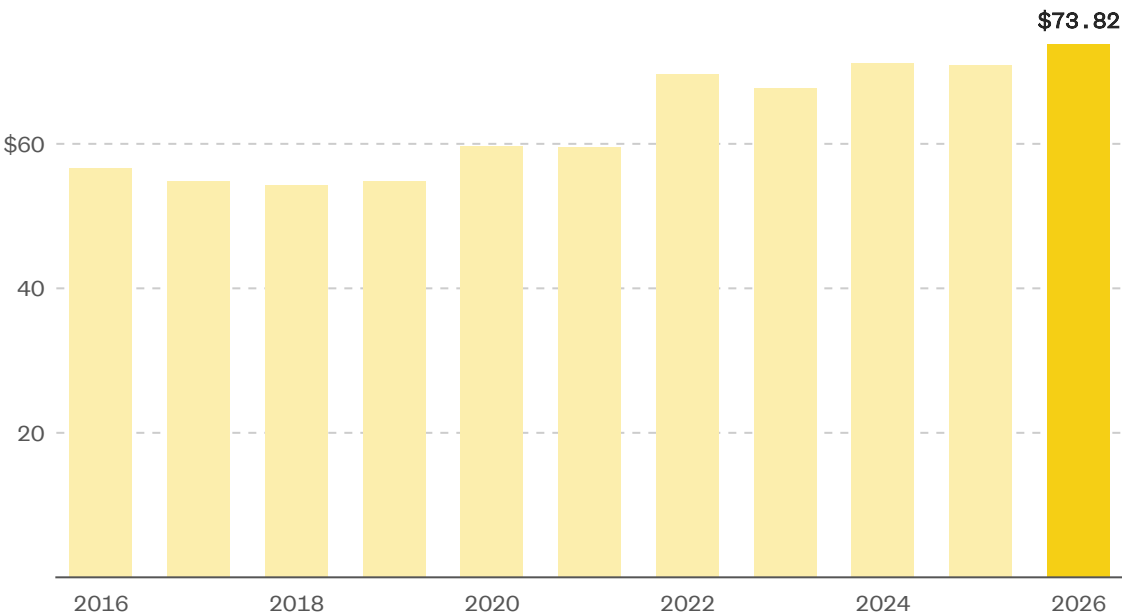
This Fourth of July, Americans can expect to feel the heat from the glow of fireworks, a nationwide heat wave and inflationary pressures on their wallets.

Average food prices for a party of 10 gathering for a Fourth of July cookout reached \$73.82 this year, the priciest grocery bag in the past decade, [according to data from the American Farm Bureau Federation](#).

At this hypothetical picnic, the menu features classic American fare: cheeseburgers, chicken breasts, pork chops, potato chips, pork and beans, fresh strawberries, homemade potato salad, fresh-squeezed lemonade, chocolate chip cookies and ice cream.

Barbecue prices fire up

The average cost of a 10-person Fourth of July picnic rose to \$73.82 this year.



Notes: Prices include cookout staples: cheeseburgers, chicken breasts, pork chops, potato chips, pork and beans, strawberries, potato salad ingredients, lemonade ingredients, chocolate chip cookies, and ice cream.

Source: [American Farm Bureau Federation](#)

Graphic: Ashley Mowreader / NBC News

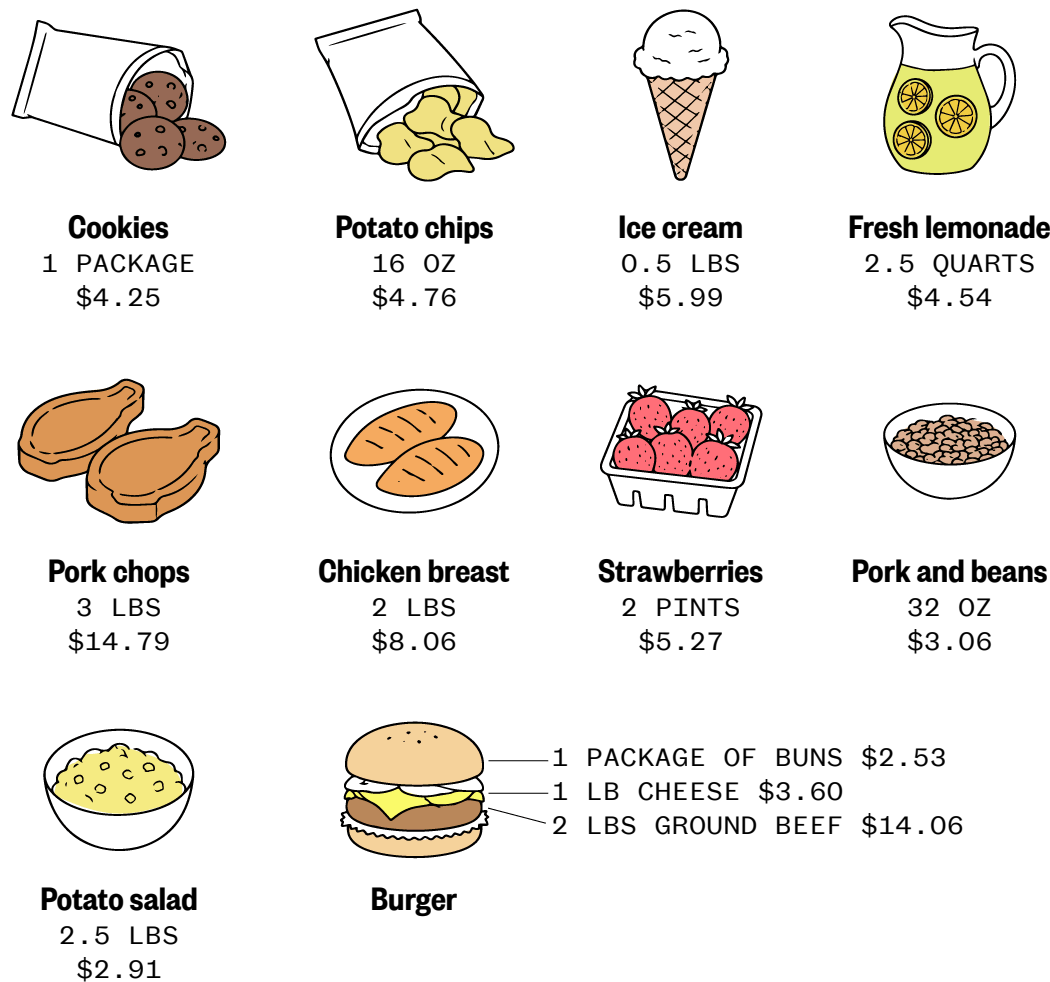
Inflation [hit 4.2% in May](#) with rising energy and food prices fueling the increase. The [war with Iran has been a significant driver](#) of food price increases, with fertilizer supply limited as the Strait of Hormuz remains bottlenecked. Compared with this time last year, [grocery prices](#) are 3% higher on the whole, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics.

[Shoppers across the U.S.](#) are seeing variability in prices, with Independence Day hosts in the West paying closer to \$80 for their 10-person party, while those in the Northeast will

spend closer to \$71 on festive foods, according to the Farm Bureau’s survey data. Each year, the Farm Bureau collects grocery price data from volunteer shoppers across the country, which it then uses for its survey.

Ground beef is one of the most expensive items in this year’s cookout basket. Two pounds of ground beef costs \$14.06, [5.5% higher than last year](#) and the highest price recorded in the Farm Bureau’s survey.

The price of a Fourth of July cookout



Source: American Farm Bureau Federation
Graphic: Ashley Mowreader and Jiachuan Wu / NBC News

Fresh fruits are more expensive this year due to poor weather in the spring as well as greater labor costs, transportation and fuel costs that pushed sticker prices higher. The cost of 2 pints of strawberries is up 12.4% compared with last summer at \$5.27.

While inflationary pressures are putting a damper on some Americans’ 250th birthday parties, economic uncertainties are also contributing to pessimism about the country’s future at the next milestone. [A recent Pew Research Center study](#) found over half of

Americans believe the U.S. economy will be weaker in 2050, with young people least likely to forecast economic strength.

Ashley Mowreader

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